



Filed as Compliant, Delivered Regardless

An Interview Study of How Delivery Workers Decide at a No Junk Mail Letterbox Sticker, Against a Council Register That Logs It as Settled

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Abstract. A council's junk-mail compliance-audit program logs a stickered letterbox as a settled matter once the sticker is installed: an audit walk records the address as compliant or not, on a binary that has held stable since the register's introduction. What actually reaches the box in any given week is decided elsewhere, by an admail distributor or a parcel courier who may never see the register at all. We interviewed 48 delivery workers (28 admail distributors, 20 parcel couriers) across six suburbs served by one council's audit program over a 14-week fieldwork window, coding transcripts to saturation and cross-referencing accounts against ten monthly rounds of the council's own audit register covering 1,140 stickered addresses. The register's logged compliance rate holds at 95-99% across every round we observed, while self-reported rates of treating the sticker as binding start below 55% and rise only gradually. Distributors describe a small catalogue of judgment calls the register has no room to record; couriers overwhelmingly report that the sticker was never addressed to them in the first place, a distinction the audit walk does not appear to make. An ablation varying whether the interview guide named the sticker upfront left the number of discretion themes coded per transcript statistically unchanged. We discuss what a stable compliance register can and cannot be taken to show about a household's actual mail.

Introduction

A “no junk mail” sticker is, from a council compliance program's point of view, a closed question. Once installed, the address enters the audit register as opted out, and subsequent audit walks ask only whether the register's binary still holds: compliant, or not. The sticker's own household-level efficacy has been measured directly, with adoption studies in Barcelona and Amsterdam finding meaningful but partial reductions in unsolicited paper reaching the box [1], [2], and the wider default-nudge literature treats the sticker as exactly the kind of low-friction opt-out that should, in principle, resolve the household's preference once and for all [3]. What that literature does not examine is the audit register itself: the record a council keeps of whether the sticker is “working” at a given address, and what an audit walk actually observes when it ticks that box.

The register's binary is a proxy for a much less binary set of decisions, made weekly and out of the register's view. An admail distributor deciding whether to leave a flyer at a stickered box, and a parcel courier delivering something the sticker was never written to cover, both produce the same visible fact — something sitting in the box — that an audit walk may or may not distinguish. Formal compliance structures loosening from the ground activity they are meant to track is a familiar pattern in organisational research [4], and studied directly in frontline public-service settings under the banner of street-level discretion [5], [6]. Unaddressed-mail delivery has not, to our knowledge, been examined as one such setting.

This paper reports an interview study of the delivery workers who actually pass stickered letterboxes, cross-referenced against one

council's own audit register over the same period. Our contributions:

- We catalogue the judgment calls admail distributors report making at a stickered box, and show they cluster differently from the reasons parcel couriers give for the same visible outcome.
- We compare the register's logged compliance rate against workers' self-reported rate of treating the sticker as binding, across the same ten audit rounds, and find the two track different things.
- We show, via an ablation on the interview guide, that these accounts surface regardless of whether the sticker is named to the interviewee upfront — suggesting the discretion is a stable feature of the round, not an artefact of how we asked about it.

Related work

Street-level bureaucracy scholarship documents how frontline workers exercise discretion that formal policy does not anticipate, from automated eligibility systems [5] to weak-state service delivery [6], civil-military coordination [7], and policy implementation under political pressure [8]. This literature typically studies workers whose discretion is visible to the institution, if not always welcomed by it; our setting is one where the institution's register has no mechanism for observing discretion at all.

Delivery and courier work has drawn growing attention as a site of algorithmic and managerial control, particularly in food-delivery platforms [9], [10], and earlier sociological accounts of postal rounds describe how a route's managerial standards, the occupational group's own regulation, and individual delivery strategies interact to shape what actually happens on a beat [11], with the physical and psychological demands of high-volume rounds documented separately [12]. None of this work addresses unaddressed-mail delivery specifically, or the compliance register a council keeps of it.

Formal registers diverging from the activity they record is the organisational pattern named by decoupling [4], examined empirically in audit contexts as the gap between substantive and symbolic compliance [13]. The junk-mail sticker itself has been evaluated as a household-level nudge, with field measurements of the paper actually prevented [1], [2] and broader design

guidance on default-based opt-outs [3] — but always at the level of the household's preference, never at the level of the register that is meant to track whether that preference is being honoured.

Prior work at this institution has traced comparable gaps between a status marker and the behaviour underneath it: a “still at large” lost-dog alert persisting for a median of eleven days after a council pound's own microchip-scan record shows the dog already returned home [14], and parents' trust in a playground safety-inspection tag sliding far less than their own independent equipment checks once the tag's date lapses [15]. Neither examines a compliance register specifically, but both suggest the gap between a marker and the practice it stands in for is not unique to this setting.

Method

We recruited 48 delivery workers across six suburbs served by a single council's junk-mail compliance-audit program: 28 admail distributors contracted to deliver unaddressed catalogues and flyers, and 20 parcel couriers whose loads are addressed mail and parcels rather than admail. Recruitment ran through the council's own distributor contact list and, for couriers, informal depot-level networks, over a 14-week fieldwork window.

Interviews were semi-structured, 25-40 minutes, and audio-recorded with consent. Half the sample received a guide that named the letter-box sticker in the opening question; the other half received a guide that asked broadly about “things that make you pause at a letterbox” and let the sticker surface on its own, if it did — the ablation reported in Results. Transcripts were coded independently by two coders using a codebook developed inductively on the first twelve transcripts and refined to saturation by the twenty-eighth [16], following a reflexive thematic-analysis procedure [17]. Inter-coder agreement was computed as Cohen's κ ,

$$\kappa = \frac{p_o - p_e}{1 - p_e},$$

where p_o is observed agreement and p_e is agreement expected by chance; the coders reached $\kappa = 0.79$ on the final codebook, comfortably inside the range guidance treats as reflecting genuinely shared coding rather than coincidence [18], [19].

Coded accounts were cross-referenced against the council's own audit register: ten monthly rounds covering 1,140 addresses carrying a currently active sticker, each round logging every address as compliant or non-compliant against the same criterion the program has used since its introduction. No identifying information about individual delivery workers or households appears in the register or in this report.

Results

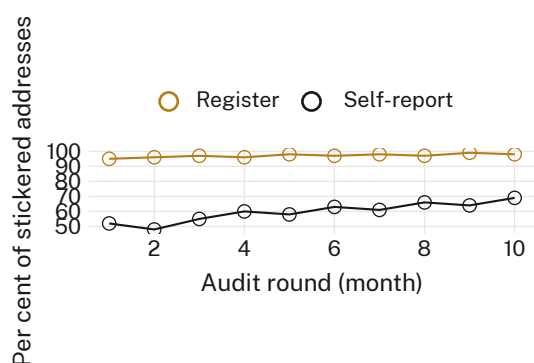


Figure 1: The register's logged compliant rate holds at 95-99% across all ten audit rounds; the self-reported rate of treating the sticker as binding starts at 52% in round 1 and reaches only 69% by round 10.

The register and the interview accounts move on different axes. Across the ten rounds we observed, the audited compliance rate never drops below 95% and shows no discernible trend. Self-reported treatment of the sticker as binding starts substantially lower, at 52% in the first round, and rises gradually to 69% by the tenth — a movement the register's own figure does not register at all, since it was already reporting near-ceiling compliance throughout.

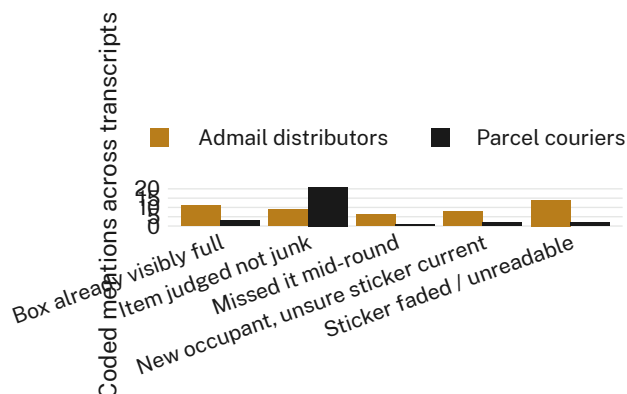


Figure 2: Admail distributors' top reasons for leaving something anyway cluster on sticker legibility and box condition; parcel couriers' reasons cluster overwhelmingly (21 of 48 coded mentions) on the item not being admail in the first place.

The two worker populations give structurally different accounts of the same outcome. Admail distributors describe a small catalogue of judgment calls — a faded or torn sticker, a box already visibly full, an item they judge is not “really” junk (a rates notice, a community newsletter), a missed address mid-round, or a new occupant whose sticker's currency is unclear. Parcel couriers, delivering addressed parcels rather than admail, report overwhelmingly that the sticker simply was not written for their load; 21 of 48 coded mentions in this group fall in that category, more than four times the comparable count among distributors. The audit register, which records only whether something was left in the box during the walk, does not appear to distinguish which of these accounts, if either, produced what the auditor found.

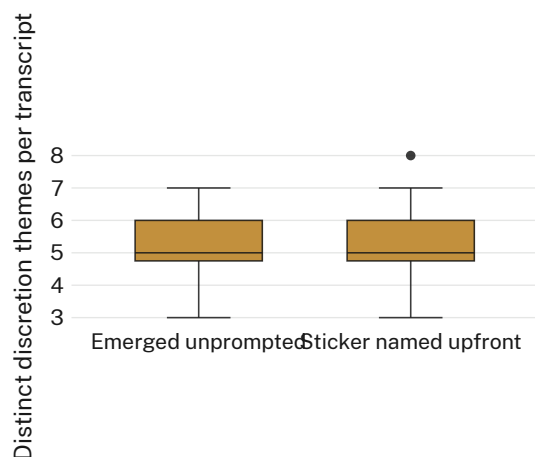


Figure 3: Distinct discretion themes coded per transcript are statistically indistinguishable between guides that named the sticker upfront and guides that let it emerge unprompted (Mann-Whitney U , $p = 0.71$).

An ablation on the interview guide — naming the sticker in the opening question versus letting it surface unprompted — left the number of distinct discretion themes coded per transcript essentially unchanged (medians 5 and 5; Mann-Whitney U , $p = 0.71$). Workers who were never asked about the sticker directly raised it, and the judgment calls around it, at close to the same rate as workers who were asked outright.

Discussion

Taken together, these results suggest the register’s compliance figure is best read as a measure of the audit walk’s own criterion — something visibly absent from the box — rather than a measure of whether a distributor’s or courier’s decision-making has changed. The two groups’ reasons for the same visible outcome differ enough that a single binary plausibly collapses two distinct phenomena into one figure: a distributor’s genuine judgment call, and a courier’s delivery of something the sticker was never meant to address. The stability of the register’s own number across all ten rounds is consistent with either a genuinely stable underlying practice or an audit criterion insensitive to the variation the interviews surface; our design cannot fully separate the two, though the self-reported trend moving independently of the register’s flat line is suggestive of the latter.

Limitations

Our sample is drawn from a single council’s compliance-audit program, though the consistency

of the reasons catalogue across two structurally distinct worker populations suggests the pattern is unlikely to be an artefact of this particular scheme. Self-reported rates of treating a sticker as binding are, inevitably, self-reported; we treat the gap between the register and the interviews as the primary finding rather than treating either figure as uniquely authoritative. The ablation addresses only interview-guide framing, not the audit walk’s own criterion, which we were not in a position to alter.

Conclusion

A compliance register that has looked the same for ten months is not, on this evidence, proof that the household preference it tracks has stopped changing — only that the register’s own instrument was never built to see the level at which it does. Future work might instrument the audit walk itself, alongside the workers it audits, to establish whether a criterion this stable can be made more sensitive to the judgment calls delivery workers already report making today.

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